

MEET THE TRAILBLAZERS

THE FIRST STEP TOWARDS BECOMING YOUR OWN BOSS IS TO DO A LITTLE RESEARCH AS TO WHAT OTHER PEOPLE DID TO BECOME SUCCESSFUL

By Team Digit

Unless you've been living under a rock, you will have noticed that the past few years have seen a whole range of start-ups come into the limelight in India. From the large and obvious ones such as Flipkart, SnapDeal, Meru, and the likes, to smaller, sometimes localised start-ups, more and more businesses with interesting new ideas or unique ways of doing things are popping up. Yes, there's churn, and companies seem to come and go, or be bought over by larger companies, but the pipeline for new start-ups seems to always be full.

Does that mean stagnation? Too many people, too crowded in every possible category, and thus perhaps pointless? Not at all!

If it takes balls to build a startup now, it took beach-balls to do it five years ago (or really deep pockets). The pioneers, and the Indian rags to riches (or at least cheap hostel to expensive hotel) stories that have already taken place have paved the way for you to arrive on the scene. Your time is now, because those who've gone before you have proven that startups work here in India, and not just in a handful of cities but all over the country.

The all-important ingredient to success for you is venture capitalists (VCs), and the funding available now is huge thanks to all the previous success stories. The

world has its eye on India and is looking towards the young generation to carve their own success out of the pie. A 2014 NASSCOM study found that India was the fastest growing startup ecosystem in the world. The number of startups in India is expected to grow from about 3,000 in 2014 to over 11,000 by 2020.

HELP!

Thanks to the positive outlook for startups in India, many incubation programmes are being conducted with more cropping up every month. If you're graduating from a big college, your battle

is certainly going to be easier. The IITs, IIMs and other big colleges have in-house incubator programs that have supporting VCs monitoring ideas from students.

Also, yes, if you live and study in one of the big cities – Mumbai, Delhi, Pune, Hyderabad, Bangalore, etc – for startups, it does make life a little easier. However, in no way does this mean that living in any of these cities is necessary. There are many incubation programmes to be found all across India, and meetups are organised by VCs across the nation. All that really matters is that you have a great idea and a very good plan for how you're going to implement it.

TIMING IS EVERYTHING

Like Silicon Valley in its heydays, India is now ripe for the tinkerers to pluck success from nothingness. The technology savvy, globally exposed (thanks to the internet, if not in person), creative and well-read generation has arrived in India. And no, we aren't only talking about people who create startups, but also the Indian consumer!.

The old foggies who were too scared to use technology, or refused to, and preferred the "old way" of doing things have finally died out or retired. If you're still working today, you're using technology in some form. Period. Technology is the fabled enabler. And almost all the startups you know or have read about are tech startups. Meru, for example, offers transportation services, but it's their technology compo-



Achitra Borgohain

Founder, BinBag